

Women Making Image: In Front, Behind, Inside

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Option A

Film Link: [IN FRONT, BEHIND, INSIDE FINAL FILM.mp4](#)

‘In front’ is the submissive position, in relation to the camera. Should you find yourself on the receiving end of a lens, you may be about to experience total domination. Remain calm, and well posed. The camera may manipulate everything in its frame, leaving you at its mercy, under the operator’s authority. It is *his* perception of you on screen. *His* gaze. (Mulvey, 1975). He reaches out an extended finger, heading for the shutter button. White ignites the studio momentarily. You’ve been shot.

Erin Hill’s *Never Done: A History of Women’s Work in Media Production* (2016) unearths the progress, or lack thereof, of women’s roles behind-the-scenes of filmmaking since the dawn of cinema, revealing a recession occurring in response to the industrialisation of Hollywood that allowed gender bias to infiltrate the studio system. Women’s initial access to authoritative creative and technical roles, including screenwriting, directing, and cinematography, rapidly narrowed, pushing them towards positions considered more feminine: costume design, hand-painting reels, clerk duties, tour guides etc. Under the sexist assumptions that considered these jobs ‘women’s work’, they became lower-paid, undervalued, and therefore undocumented in cinematic history. This continued across the 20th century, peaking in the 1960s, as argued by J.E. Smyth in *Nobody’s Girl Friday: The Women Who Ran Hollywood* (2018). Instigated by the popularisation of auteurism throughout the era, directors became of even higher status than previously thought, due to the theory’s centralisation of them as the sole author of their films (Truffaut, 1955), (Sarris, 1962). Coincidentally, the directors championed by this were, by vast majority, white males, shining an even brighter spotlight on men in filmmaking, and darkening the shadows over others.

“Women accounted for 26% of producers, 21% of executive producers, 20% of editors, 20% of writers, 10% of directors, and 7% of cinematographers” working on the top 100 highest grossing films of 2025 in the U.S. (Lauzen, 2026), while the aforementioned ‘women’s work’ roles discussed by Hill remain dominated by women a century later. The disproportionate access to technical and senior creative positions for women exposes the gatekeeping by men

in the industry, aiding the decline in percentage of female cinematographers, a clear indication of the masculinisation of technology and image-making apparatus. Amidst a research project based on late 20th century camerawomen, Katie Bird's video essay *With a Camera in Hand, I was Alive* (2021) questions, "what does a camera's weight mean to a woman?". Bird expresses her own desire to handle a camera; the desire "to lift, to hold, to open, to click", as though the camera is a "phantom limb", an extension of herself, and how the shape and weight of the apparatus affect your proprioception, and therefore, attention to and interaction with surroundings. The desktop documentary discloses the conversation topics that often arise in Bird's conference Q&A sessions, deconstructing the common implication in the industry that women biologically do not possess the physical strength or endurance to operate the camera, based on the longstanding sexist association with male bodies and large, heavy machinery. "As if the problem was strength, as if the problem was about endurance, as if the problem could be as simple as... how much does a camera weigh?" (Bird, 2021).

All this is to say, the position behind the camera is viewed as a masculine one, and conversely, therefore, **in front is feminine**. Actress and Director Kristen Stewart spoke recently about this in an interview with The New York Times, stating "performance is inherently vulnerable and therefore quite embarrassing and unmasculine... there's no bravado in suggesting that you're a mouthpiece now for someone else's ideas... it's just inherently submissive". The standoff between male director/cinematographer/photographer and female subject, intercepted by the lens, is a blueprint for the gendered positioning surrounding the camera. Consequently, the imagery and narratives produced under this industry are intrinsically formulated and distributed to serve and benefit male audiences. Laura Mulvey's catalytic essay *Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema* first introduced the "male gaze" to readers of Screen in 1975, stating "in a world ordered by sexual imbalance, pleasure in looking has been split between active/male and passive/female". Female characters throughout cinematic history have been written and recorded only for the pleasure of the male spectator, giving the cameraman the dominance

that constrains women into that submissive position, “to connote to-be-looked-at-ness”, discussed by Mulvey.

Susan Sontag’s collection of essays, *On Photography* (1977), discusses the controlling act of taking an image, the aggression and potential perversion of enforcing one’s lens onto the world, and the placing of subjects as consumable objects, like an act of voyeurism. Relating back to Katie Bird’s expressions of the camera as a “phantom limb” and the masculine affiliation with technology, one cannot help but consider the correlations between the camera, and the act of photographing/filming, and phallic imagery/sexual acts. Sontag claims, “between photographer and subject, there has to be a distance. The camera doesn’t rape, or even possess, though it may presume, intrude, trespass, distort, exploit, and, at the farthest reach of metaphor, assassinate – all activities that, unlike the sexual push and shove, can be conducted from a distance, and with some detachment... The camera as phallus is, at most, a flimsy variant of the inescapable metaphor that everyone unselfconsciously employs. However hazy our awareness of this fantasy, it is named without subtlety whenever we talk about ‘loading’ and ‘aiming’ a camera, about ‘shooting’ a film” (Sontag, 1977). The significance of physical distance in this analogy, and the camera’s invasive tendencies, lends itself towards thoughts of the camera in non-consensual settings, hidden to capture secret images and videos of women in public, often in forms of upskirting or, more recently, trends using Ray-Ban Meta AI Glasses. For just £400 a pop, you too can exploit and invade the privacy of strangers without their knowledge or consent for the benefit of your social media page! Said pages, dedicated to non-consensual footage of women in public, are increasing in quantity, and volume of views, subjecting innocent and unsuspecting women to thousands of derogatory and sexually explicit comments. Though the glasses have an LED light to indicate they are recording, multiple users on tiktok have uploaded tutorials on how to cover this, increasing their incognito-ness and furthering the evidence towards the fetishistic obsession with capturing image and video of women in pursuance of sexual power.

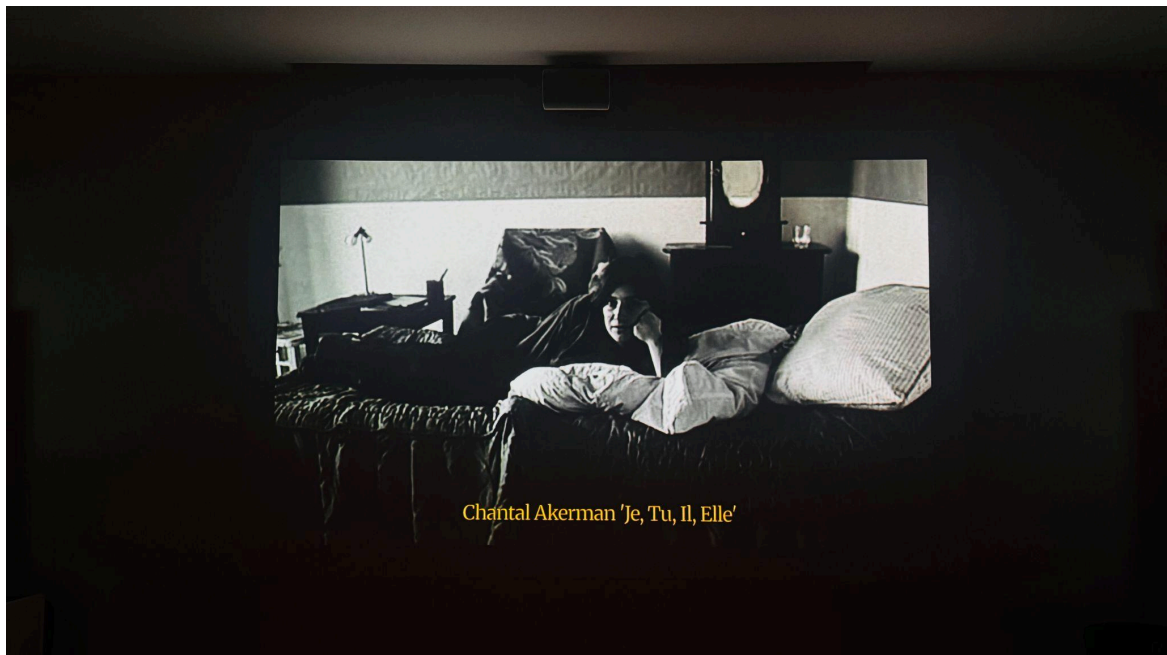
I've been considering the camera as a fashion accessory, not only in the form of glasses, but slung round the body on a strap. Patriarchal frameworks teach us that masculinity is cool, and in turn, femininity is degrading, therefore, the masculinity of the camera is a symbol of status, an indication of creative liberty, and a public presentation of power. The masculine camera grants 'coolness' unto its wearer, as though the wearing of the camera is the addition of a male appendage and masculine power. I have a constant relationship with the camera, as a performance-filmmaker, and am influenced most by the work of women in image-making who venture beyond the aforementioned blueprints of the camera's gender dynamics, repositioning themselves into states of power and denying the camera as a male object.



¹ Collier, A. (2008). *Woman With A Camera (Cheryl Tiegs/Olympus)* [Photograph]. [Projection Image by Me].

‘Behind’ the camera is a vantage point. Your perspective has opened, and the set bares itself to you, surrendering to your control. It’s now your turn to inflict your gaze upon the image, your turn to shoot.

French filmmaker, Chantal Akerman, situates herself both in-front, as subject, and behind, as director, in her film *Je, Tu, Il, Elle* (1974), producing a narrative and image of absolute feminine gaze. Julie, the protagonist, traps herself inside her bedroom as she endures emotional turmoil post-breakup across, what we are told to be, “at least 28 days” in diegetic time, spanning the first approximately 30 minutes of the film. The longevity of the scene restricts the audience’s contextual knowledge of the narrative world, as opposed to explicitly establishing an immediate premise, so we are only permitted exposure to Julie and her room for such an extent of the film. The sequence feels incredibly vulnerable, and evoked something almost documentative, as though it was just herself and her camera alone in the space, disproven by the occasional tracking shots that suggest a camera operator is present. However, the ways in which Julie/Akerman bares herself, physically and emotionally, to the camera in so few and such mundane words and actions, accompanied by the time-based essence of the scene, I couldn’t help but observe the footage as though it were documentation of a performance art piece. As though Julie was not a character, but real. This becomes even more potent in Julie’s acknowledgment of the camera, staring through the lens at us, registering our surveillance. We are forced into immense intimacy and familiarity with her, the space, and the time; time being of great relevance to Akerman as a director, explaining, “when people are enjoying a film they say ‘I didn’t see the time go by’... but I think that when time flies and you don’t see time passing by, you are robbed of an hour and a half or two hours of your life. Because all you have in life is time. With my films, you’re aware of every second passing through your body” (Akerman, 2012). There is an intentional endurance of time required from the audience, and a kind-of liveness to the screening, keeping us in step with Julie and her month-long self-entrapment.



I'm currently consumed by a social media algorithm of discourse on male and female hormone cycles, and how our society's 24-hour routine structure is based on that of the former where testosterone, providing fuel and focus, peaks in the morning and reduces by evening, recurring daily, attune to the 9-5 system that runs the majority of civilisation. The female 28-day cycle is left unacknowledged and underresearched, leaving bodies that experience a progesterone and estrogen-led hormone pattern, at a daily disadvantage. Julie's month-long disorder, and Akerman's recognition of time, provoked the question, given society's scheduling and the male gaze's grip on cinema, have we been almost only subject to a male understanding of time, and therefore the translation of that onto the screen? More importantly, do female filmmakers interpret pacing alternatively? I don't like to say 'alternatively' as though a male understanding is default and female is secondary (de Beauvoir, 1949), I mean this only in reference to the chronological order and biased ranking of gender acknowledgement in the film industry. I also do not mean that women then inherently make slower films, more so that there may be more of a lingering mood or tone throughout female-made films, reminiscent of the hormone cycle and its extended continuance.

² Akerman, C. (1974). *Je, Tu, Il, Elle* [Film Still]. [Projection Image by Me].

In 1996, *Cinéastes de notre temps* (Cinema of our Time), a documentary series celebrating and investigating significant filmmakers, their work, and process, requested a self-portrait-style episode from Akerman, for which she presented a re-cut assemblage of her filmography titled *Chantal Akerman par Chantal Akerman*. She introduces the edit; “the best way to make this self-portrait would be to let my films speak for themselves... I’d edit them together and create a new film which would then become a portrait of myself”. *Gendered Frames, Embodied Cameras* (McFadden, 2014) devotes a chapter, *Enacted Reflexivity*, to the study of this episode, and to the consideration of it as a ‘self-portrait’, noting “Akerman presents two bodies in her self-portrait: her physical body and her body of work... suggest[ing] utmost confidence in her cinematic production: her films would be her body, give her shape”. Physically, visually, and audibly present in front of the camera, and/or narratively, artistically, and directorially present even when behind-camera, Akerman’s films are her total self expression, body and mind. Therefore, even in her films unlike *Je, Tu, Il, Elle*, where she remains only behind the camera, not in front, she is still perpetually omnipresent on screen because the film is a depiction of herself. To be **behind the camera, is to expose yourself** in front, potentially even more so than when face-to-face with the lens.

Contrarily, Cindy Sherman’s photography series, *Untitled Film Stills* (1977-1980), for which she is both model and photographer, are not such a pure manifestation of herself, though she commands both sides of the camera, but rather an investigation into the stereotyping and compression of female characters in cinema. Sherman not only plays actress and camera-coordinator, but is also the stylist, hair and makeup artist, and set and lighting designer, encompassing every role required to create the image without assistance, claiming auteur-istic governance of her static-shot cinematic worlds. The process of styling herself as these idolized characters from the big screen, and temporarily crossing the barrier between unattainable starlet persona and adoring spectator reveals the illusions of fashion and the camera, enlightening viewers further on the manufacturing of cinema and relationship between costume and women on screen, becoming all the more obvious when given

eye-opening access to perspectives in front of and behind the camera. "I know I was not consciously aware of this thing the 'male gaze'... semiconsciously at best, I was wrestling with some sort of turmoil of my own about understanding women... they weren't just airhead actresses... the clothes make them seem a certain way, but then you look at their expression,... and wonder if maybe 'they' are not what the clothes are communicating" (Sherman, 1990).

The characters in the photographs often bare almost expressionless faces, or very subtle articulation in tense eyebrows or an open jaw, as though they have been naturally caught mid-scene, rather than in a moment of heightened drama, yet the camera still maintains an overarching presence, given its cinematic positioning, like an invasion of the women's privacy, as though we intrude on their solitude and vulnerability like a voyeuristic viewer.

Communities of women I have come across online explain an experience similar to this, claiming to feel constantly observed, even when completely alone, as though there is a camera or invisible male audience they must constantly perform for and be attractive to, exemplifying the effects of the male gaze on women's daily lives and how we subconsciously and involuntarily absorb and internalise its manifesto. Sherman's photographs go beyond merely playing dress-up; they demonstrate the unwavering pressure on women to appear 'screen-ready' visually, and submissive, narratively, with or without the presence of a camera.

The images simultaneously comment on the devaluing of female stories on-screen, not only in their costumed caricatures of lazily-written stereotypes, but in the implication that Sherman's characters are not the only ones in the narrative. "Some of the photographs are meant to be solitary women and some are meant to allude to another person outside the frame" (Sherman, 1990). The Bechdel Test measures whether or not two female characters in a film have a conversation with one another about something other than a man (Bechdel, 1985), a shockingly rare occurrence in movies, especially at the time Sherman began the series. Therefore, the implication, or natural assumption of many viewers, would be that the pictured women are mid-interaction with a male counterpart. However, Sherman's camera

re-centres the narrative around these female characters, forcing you to remain permanently with them and cultivate a new context that would otherwise be a depthless device to progress the tale of their male counterpart.



Before beginning the *Untitled Film Stills*, Sherman would “dress as different female and male characters, pose, photograph [herself], print the photo... cut out the figure, and use it in little scenarios. There was a leading actress, a leading man, a director – generic characters from a Hollywood murder mystery... But [she] was bothered by them: [she] thought this work was too feminine, with the dolls and the cutting... [she] knew [she] wanted to go on making little narratives, but without using other people. [She] wanted to work alone... wanted a controlled situation in [her] studio”. This desire to escape the bounds of work considered ‘feminine’ in the cinematic space, just as Hill has observed, the auteur-istic urge to dominate and understand every aspect of the process in pursuance of total control over the product and its depiction of women, is a yearning I share with Sherman.

³ Sherman, C. (1977-1980). *Untitled Film Stills #14 & #10* [Photographs]. [Projection Image by Me].

'Inside', you find this. Your body becomes the apparatus. As you peer around at the world beyond the studio, it is nothing but yours to capture and distribute. You are the ultimate domination of image. You are the gun.

I'm incredibly intrigued by female performance artists who use their bodies in interaction with costume and prop to transform themselves into an object, with the simultaneous intention of opposing the objectification of female bodies. Lindsay Seers discusses this complex in an interview with Tate (2018), in relation to photographs she had taken of herself nude with flowers coming out from inside of her vagina, claiming "to me it was a parody of this objectification... but when I showed them to people they said they were beautiful, and then I realised that... you can't really critique something from within it, in a sense that you fall into all the same traps". Since her years as an art student, Seers' interests in the impact of the camera on women's bodies has been reflected in her work, and this recognition of what appears to the artist as an ironic, satirical imitation instead becoming misconceived by viewers, risking reclamation by the very thing you are attempting to undermine, ignited the project *Optograms (Mouth Camera)* (1997-2020). In the same interview, Seers explains her initial hypothesis, "I needed to rethink the relationship between the subject and the object in photography, and so if I was the camera, then there's no dislocation". In a raw display of the perspective from inside the female body, Seers puts a small circle of photographic paper into her mouth, her body standing as the tripod, her lips becoming the aperture. By personifying the camera, capturing the subject inside of her mouth, the image-making becomes an act of cannibalism, consuming the people she photographs, and digesting the scenes. "There is an image, a fuzzy image of you, now on the back of my throat... you'd be upside down, and I'd be about to swallow you". **Inside her, the subject and object coalesce.**

When exhibiting these little, round, ingested images from inside of the human camera, they're often alongside a documentary image of Seers' external body in position, taking the photograph, capturing the moment of transformation from body into brief object.

The power of the camera is not phallic or masculine, it's a female body.



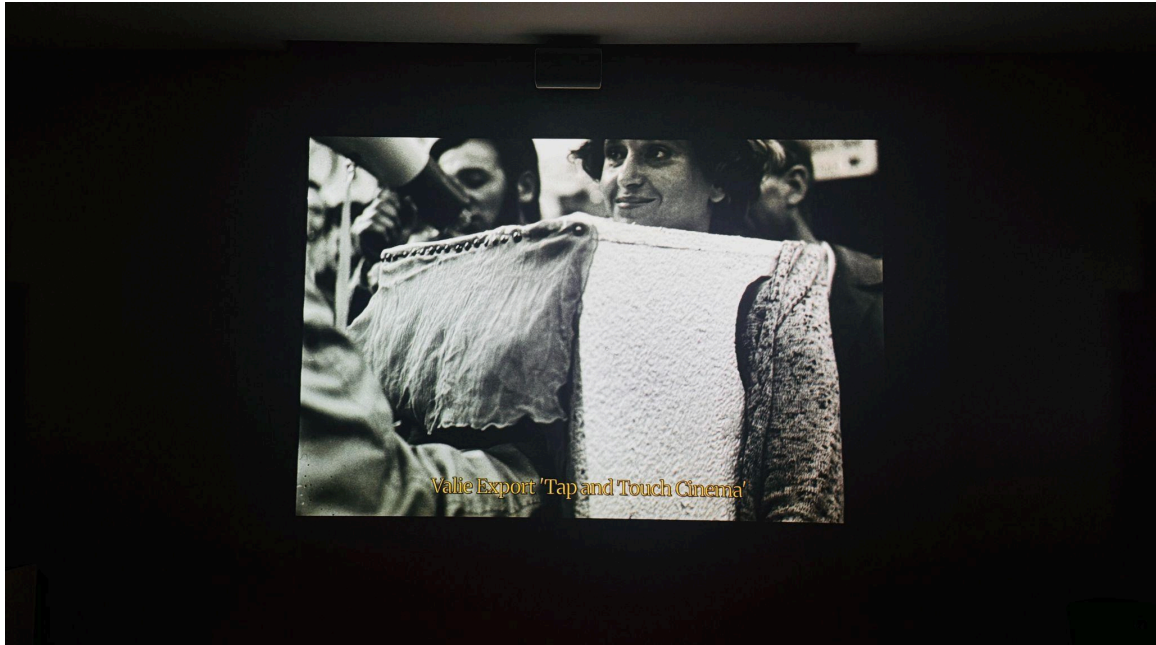
In another form of self-objectification, Narcissister, a sculpture, costume, and performance artist, becomes the mother of moving image in *Narcissister Automata with Praxinoscope (Jump Rope)* (2025). Thematically, throughout her practice, Narcissister employs a body double in the form of mannequins and masks, aiding in her anonymity and play between body and object, this performing-sculpture being no exception. An animatronic clone of herself moves with audience participation, the turning of a bike wheel activating the cogs, and spinning analogue moving-image into action on the praxinoscope at her crotch. The device appears to have come out from inside of her vagina, invoking the suggestion that she is birthing motion picture. But, at the other end of the mannequin, the head is forced up and down by the mechanism, with wide, pried-open eyes, and the unnerving comprehension that her lifeless, constrained body is compelled into operation by the audience as they so please, becomes reminiscent of oppressed and exploited women in film, especially upon noticing the hypersexualised figure that the mannequin adorns.

⁴ Seers, L. (1997-2020). *Optograms (Mouth Camera)* [Photograph]. [Projection Image by Me].

Stripped back, this idea of constructing a sexualised clone of a real woman and generating images with this is an exact, current occurrence across the world, with the rise in use of AI for pornographic intent. “The market for AI-driven adult content will be worth \$2.5billion this year... and it is expected to grow at a constant rate of 27% a year until 2028... A second concern is deepfake technology, which can turn anyone’s likeness into porn... [in] less than 25 minutes... from a single clear headshot... increasingly, the victims are ordinary people” (The Economist, 2025), and unsurprisingly, majority female. There is less reliance on the camera to attempt domination and exploitation of women in image, rather than the imposing lens, it is camera-less technology fabricating non-consensual, derogatory images. AI has been used to remove women’s clothes in images, apply her face to pornographic material, and undoubtedly worse. Unlike the Ray-Ban Meta AI glasses that at least expose the offender, the AI-users remain anonymous and undetected in the security of their caves, curating themselves an archive of vulgar material.

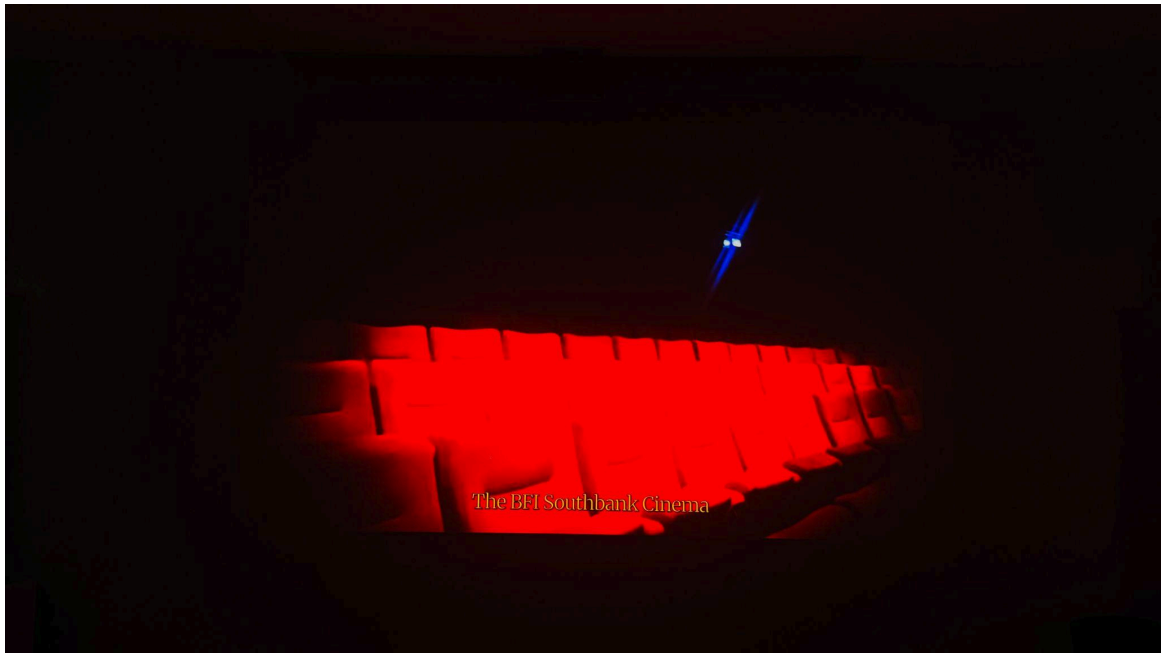
Rather than this secretive consumption of image, Valie Export forces audiences and participants of her work, *Tap and Touch Cinema* (1968), into confrontation with the female bodies they exploit on screen. In a live performance on the streets of Munich, Export and collaborator, Peter Weibel, invite members of the public for a trip to the ‘cinema’ – the ‘cinema’ being a styrofoam box strapped to Export’s otherwise naked torso, where participants would reach their hand through curtains at the front, into the ‘theatre’, and touch the artist’s breasts. The intention of the interaction was to deconstruct the solely audio visual based pleasure of cinema that instigates the sexualised and glamorized image of female bodies and their purpose for male pleasure, by creating an experience exclusively touch-based. Foregoing these circumstances that cinema typically relies on to generate that pleasure-based environment in which women on-screen submit to the audience, and in-turn, audiences submit their senses to the screen, Export transforms spectators into participators, regrounding them in the real, fleshy physical. In her becoming of the space, going inside of the screen, she has total authority over the distribution of her ‘film’, denying being an edited, visually manipulated

image, and standing in confrontation with those inside of her space. The entire production, distribution, and consumption of Cinema is female.



⁵ Export, V. (1968). *Tap and Touch Cinema* [Photograph of Performance]. [Projection Image by Me].

I want to be the projector, spinning in the back booth like an ominous presence behind you in the theatre. I want to be the cinema in which you sit, with my red velvet legs wrapped around you and curtains of hair disclosing my screen, on which I play you my movie. I want to be the director commanding the set, awakening myself and switching on my bulb so that I may illuminate myself in a spotlight as I perform for the lens. I want to be **In Front, Behind, Inside.**



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⁶ Bevan, M. M. (2026). *BFI Southbank Cinema* [Photograph]. [Projection Image by Me].

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Wellman, W. A. (1931). *Night Nurse* [Women and Cocaine screenings curated by Caroline Cassin] [Cinema Film Screening]. The Cinema Museum.

PoE Film Credits

Music by

Strauss, R., & Dudamel, G. (1896). *Also sprach Zarathustra*.